Don't Blame it on Adam

By Anonymous Folktale

INTRODUCTION

God created Adam and Eve and placed them in a garden of numerous fruit trees from which they could eat anything, except the fruit from one tree. Although Adam and Eve had no concept of good and evil, they obviously did know about disobedience, since Eve told the serpent, "From the fruit of the trees of the garden we may eat; but from the fruit of the tree which is in the middle of the garden, God has said, 'You shall not eat from it or touch it, or you will die.'" From her statement, it is clear that Eve knew that she shouldn't eat the fruit. However, she chose to disregard the instruction and did eat of the forbidden fruit. When confronted, she did not admit fault but blamed the serpent for it. It is enough of a mistake to disobey God, but to compound it by not admitting that she was at fault was sheer folly. Adam too chose to eat of the forbidden fruit, and did the same as Eve. Instead of admitting his fault, he blamed Eve.

Today the issues of responsibility for one-s own actions is still of great concern to our society. It seems that individuals have the innate propensity to blame their misfortunes, not on their own choice, but on everything and everyone else. In this African folk-tale, a working man named Moses finally learns his lesson: Don't Blame it on Adam.

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There once was a freed slave named Moses who lived at the edge of the woods in a small hut.

Every morning Moses arose early and went deep into the forest to chop wood. Then he bundled the wood up and carried it to town to sell. Moses wouldn't have enough money to buy breakfast until he sold some wood.

So every morning a hungry Moses walked up and down the streets calling, "Wood, wood. Who will buy some of my wood? It's all the fault of Adam. Good wood for sale."

One day as Moses was selling his wood. a rich man heard what he was saying. "Who is this person," he asked, "and why does he say that it's all the fault of Adam?" Because he wanted to know the answers to these questions, the rich man went up to Moses and asked him what he meant.

This is what Moses said: "I have heard that long ago Adam disobeyed God and ate the forbidden fruit. If he had not, we would all now be living in the Garden of Eden and I would never go hungry. That is why I say it is the fault of Adam."

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"I see," said the rich man. "You work hard, yet you go hungry. It does not seem fair that you are suffering because of Adam's mistake. I will help you."

The rich man brought Moses to his house. Moses took a long, hot bath, after which the rich man gave him new clothes. Then the rich man took Moses down the hall and showed him a room in which he could stay.

The rich man said to Moses, "From now on you can call me brother. We will share everything. You can do anything you like except for one thing – you may not open the green door at the end of the hall. This is the one and only thing you may never do. Do you understand?"

Moses thanked the man and said, "What reason would I ever have to open the green door? I have food, clothes and shelter; I now have a brother who cares for me. What more could I want?"

And so Moses began a life of comfort. He never had to get up early or work hard. He had so much to eat that he was starting to get fat.

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Moses had forgotten all about the green door until one day he happened to pass by it, and as he did, he remembered that it was the door he was never to open. However, he couldn't help but wonder why he, the rich man's brother, was not allowed to find out what was in the room behind the door. Moses sighed and walked on.

During the next few days, Moses seemed to be drawn to the green door. Several times a day he found himself outside the door, and each time he became more and more curious as to what was behind it. Sometimes, without realizing it, his hand actually moved toward the handle but he managed to stop himself each time.

One day the rich man said, "Brother, I have been called away to another town, and I will not be back until late today. I am entrusting my home to you. Please take care that nothing happens."

After the rich man left Moses started thinking: "I am responsible for the house so surely I am responsible for the room behind the green door as well. I am going to find out what is hidden there."

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After checking that no one was looking, Moses put his ear against the door. He could not hear anything.

"I must know what is in there," he said to himself. " I will just open the door a crack and close it again. My brother will never know." And so Moses opened the door a tiny bit. The room was dark, but after a while Moses could see that all that was in there were the old rags he used to wear and the wood he used to sell. Just then a mouse ran out the door.

"Oh no," Moses cried. "My brother was hiding a mouse in the room and now it has escaped. I must catch it." As Moses ran after the mouse, his shoes fell off. He tripped over the bottom of his long fancy pants and had to take them off. Still, he could not catch the mouse, and now he was very tired and out of breath.

Suddenly the rich man appeared. He had returned early. "What are you doing, Moses?" boomed the rich man. "Why are you running around my house naked?"

Moses threw himself at the rich man's feet. "I'm sorry," he sobbed. "I did not mean to let your mouse go."

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"What mouse?" asked the rich man. "I have no mouse."

"The mouse in the room. When I opened the green door..."

"You opened the green door?"

"I did not mean to. It was wrong, but my feet kept taking me there, and I was curious, and I was..."

"Moses, I am very disappointed in you. Opening the green door was the one thing I told you not to do. You are as bad as Adam. You should have learned from Adam's mistake."

"I am sorry, my brother. It will never happen again. I promise. What do you wish me to do?"

The rich man's anger had disappeared. Now he had tears in his eyes. "Go back to the room," he said sadly, " and take your rags and sticks. Return to the market and sell your wood."

"Yes, sir" was all Moses could say. He returned to the market. Once again he shouted, "Good wood for sale. Who wants to buy good wood?"

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Later Moses realized that no one else can make you happy or sad – that it is up to every person to determine his or her fate. Moses worked hard, and when things went well, he looked at what he had done to make good things happen. So, too, when things went badly, he looked at what he could change and what he could not. But he never mentioned Adam again.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kantor, Susan (ed)
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AWARD HISTORY

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